

OBJECTS OF

Do women want to act out their fantasies?

No. The safe sex thought police, it seems, has taken over the female moral universe.

Desire

By Shilpa Phadke

The worried-looking woman appeals to the doctor to do something about her husband's "lack of energy". The doctor sends the man to "the room" to be revitalised—and the audience is treated to a glimpse of the room, a bathroom, as the man goes into orgasmic raptures over the fittings and the bathtub. Apparently the bathroom has worked its magic, and the man's "energy" is back, at least, in the bathroom or perhaps only for the bathroom. The women in the audience who have similarly afflicted partners can only hope.

The sexual undertones of the advertisement are apparent, but what also piques the interest are the locational overtones of these media-generated fantasies. The question, "where" is seemingly important when we talk about sex. Here it's the bathroom, in another advert it's a hotel room—in fact, according to the INDIA TODAY-AC Nielsen-ORG MARG sex survey 2009, a fairly high 34 per cent of all men surveyed with Ahmedabad leading with a whopping 72 per cent, report fantasies of sex in hotel rooms and 28 per cent have actually done this—65 per cent in Ahmedabad, and 48 per cent each in Kolkata and Ludhiana. Twenty-four per cent of all surveyed women (68 per cent in Mumbai) fantasise about sex in a hotel room while 25 per cent (50 per cent in Ludhiana) have actually done it.

Location is certainly significant—55 per cent of women fantasise about sex in their own bedrooms, but only 14 per cent each think about doing so on a beach, under a waterfall and 8 per cent on a rooftop. Among men, 67 per cent fantasise about sex in their own bedrooms as against, 6, 9 and 20 per cent respectively under a waterfall, on a beach and on a rooftop. Clearly, private spaces are much more conducive to fantasies than public spaces—or is it that we dare not think or speak of public spaces? Are we afraid of being labelled that most overused of words: "obscene"? Legally, Section 294 of the Indian Penal Code, views any kind of "obscene behaviour in public" as punishable. Obscene be-

haviour has no clear definition and anything remotely sexual that annoys the sensibilities of the strait-laced man next to you may qualify. In May this year, at a fashion week ramp walk, actor Akshay Kumar was booked for obscene behaviour in public for asking his wife to unbutton his jeans. Forget about sex, even hinting at it in public is no go for many.

And no kissing in public too. In 2004, Bollywood film star Kareena Kapoor began legal proceedings against a tabloid newspaper that published photos of her kissing her co-star and then boyfriend Shahid Kapoor, asserting that she came from a good family and would never do "that". It is interesting that Kareena chose to assert her respectability rather than her right to privacy, which might have led her to argue instead that the person had no right to shoot her in a moment of privacy and then sell the image for profit. The problem with the kiss, I would like to suggest, is that while people merely assumed that she and Shahid had a sexual life, it remained private but being confronted with the reality of that sex life threatened Kareena's status as a good girl.

If some people don't want to kiss and tell, in other spaces, it's distinctly un-kosher. Film scholar M. Madhava Prasad has eloquently argued that until the 1980s, there was an unofficial, unwritten ban on kissing in Hindi cinema, because it was, among other things, un-Indian, violating defined public private boundaries.

The fantasies sold to us through consumer-oriented imagery promise perfect sex in luxurious resorts inviting us to imagine ourselves dining on fine cuisine, sipping champagne in Belgian-made flutes or reclining in rose petal strewn spas with our significant others as incense perfumes the air. These fantasies are inevitably of two heterosexual people in private spaces. Audience not invited, except as envious "others" who can only imagine the sensual delights of these spaces. The problem with even the suggestion of public sexuality then is the publicness of it—the violation of the taboo of mixing the artificially but nonetheless firmly drawn boundaries between the private and the public. The question often asked of couples cooing